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DECOLONISING EDUCATION IN AFRICA - WHY PAN-AFRICANISM CAN BREAK THE JINX

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ABSTRACT

Shortly after gaining independence from colonialism, the project of decolonisation began across several spectrums, with education featuring prominently. Although some advances have been made since political independence, western influence on education in Africa remains a worrying phenomenon. Therefore, a Pan-African education is imperative towards weaning Africa off its colonial past while also developing the human, social, economic, and political might of the continent to become self-reliant.

The paper argues for decolonising curricula and pedagogy in Africa and why there is a need to adopt a Pan-African approach to education. Finally, the paper calls on African states, policymakers, and curriculum designers to take the lead in promoting a paradigm of Pan-African or African centred education as a means of redefining and challenging conventional knowledge systems.



INTRODUCTION

Education is a vital instrument for reducing injustice, enabling upward socio-economic mobility, and inspiring people to live healthy lives. It confers knowledge and removes ignorance. As it is popularly known, knowledge is power. Thus, education confers power and regulates the influence of the former colonialists (Adjei & Dei, 2008). Many African countries inherited the schooling systems of their colonisers (Musitha & Mafukata, 2018). The inherited education system was developed in a “Westernized form” (designed based on Western philosophy of education), displacing indigenous and traditional knowledge transfer and acquisition methods. As a result, education proved to be instrumental in the colonial agenda as schools became a potent ground for indoctrinating young Africans (Mosweunyane, 2013),

Heleta (2016, p. 9) indicates that “the subjugation of local knowledge and the propagation of Western knowledge as common knowledge was one of the most damaging consequences of colonisation”. This lends credence to the view that western education introduced western culture and value systems into Africa and destroyed indigenous knowledge systems in the process. Oral traditions which formed a fundamental core of knowledge and literacy practices in Africa were derided as backward, inefficient, and inappropriate (Abdi, 2007b).

This was particularly troubling because it had an adverse impact on indigenous languages, as local languages eventually took backstage as a medium of instruction in many schools. Musitha and Mafukata (2018)

note that the education structure of the colonialists was deliberately designed to sabotage the growth of the educational and skills development of the colonised. Rodney (1972), in his book *How Europe Underdeveloped Africa*, explained that with the imposition of alien colonial schooling and ways of knowing, aboriginal people were unexpectedly disconnected from precolonial educational structures that embodied and mirrored their backgrounds, traditions, languages, and real needs. With their philosophically deforming intentions and consequences, the modern learning arrangements were not beneficial to populations’ welfare and societies, yet successfully served the colonising entity’s needs, who was bent on optimising the dehumanising degradation of all that reflected the lives of the colonised.

Notwithstanding the progress made since gaining political independence, the influence of western education has hardly waned. The curricula and pedagogy of school are still designed to affirm western worldviews, traditions, belief systems, language, etc., while indigenous strategies and modes of teaching continue to be invalidated (Bangura, 2005). Decolonisation of education is therefore imperative. The decolonisation project must be continuous, rigorous and critical towards challenging the Eurocentric narratives that pervade the educational system in Africa (Adebisi, 2016).

Shortly after gaining independence, processes of decolonisation began in many African countries across several domains, including education. One of the goals of decolonial thinking and decolonisation as a process is to recreate, re-engrave,

personify the self-esteem, impartiality, and social equality about individuals and groups whose very existence as well as values, reasoning, perceptions, and worldviews have been violently reduced or demonised by colonist, imperial and domineering plans as well as postmodern and alter-contemporary internal criticisms (Lebeloane, 2017).

Pan-Africanism, as an ideology that centres Africa's indigenous knowledge, provides helpful remedies towards the decolonisation project. However, such ideas rarely feature in the curricula and pedagogy in Africa. Pan Africanism aims to address Africa's underdevelopment and exploitation and the continent's culture of reliance on foreign assistance by encouraging Africans to tap into their strengths to build their capacities and become self-sufficient.

Sadly, the advancement of the Right to Education, particularly by international institutions, has mainly been geared towards advancing affordability, accessibility and quality of education without regard for the philosophical underpinnings of education in Africa. These actions seem only further to westernise the products of African educational institutions. This paper intends to argue for the complete decolonisation of curricula and pedagogy in Africa and why there is a need to adopt a Pan-African approach to education.

PHILOSOPHY OF PAN-AFRICAN EDUCATION

Education philosophies typically concentrate on the logic and reasonableness of historical and regional location-specific learning initiatives. However, at the root of the entire educational enterprise is the philosophy of education. To state the argument more explicitly, Mango (2011) highlights that the central role of philosophy in shaping the foundations and approaches towards development. This introduces education philosophy as an insightful way of thinking about education. The philosophy of education provides a profound and broad framework for understanding educational issues and challenges. The interaction between education and philosophy has a definite impact on growth. Although education reveals a range of knowledge, a philosophy that shapes the core beliefs and values teaches us to retain an open and rational mind amid diverse ideas (Ibanga, 2016).

Plato (427 BC-347 BC) pointed out that education is mainly directed at the country's political and social stability in which it operates. Good education encourages good behaviour, which creates the strength and consensus required for a nation to be built. From Plato's philosophical perspective, education's objective is to place a person in the proper order, point them in the right direction, and instil in them a spirit of commitment to social resilience and togetherness (Abiogun, 2014). Indeed, this can only be done once individuals are trained in society according to their abilities. Therefore, education can serve as the key to drive socio-economic and political growth in any country.

This is based on the ideological underpinnings of a country's educational system, which encompasses aims, priorities, and expectations. Educational philosophy represents the needs and desires of the culture for which it was conceived (Apologun, 2012). Oyedepo (2000) explained that the philosophy of education tends to wake up individuals' abilities and skills to articulate their interests as members of the community.

Ezewu (1993, p. 29) argued that "education is the individual's development from within, interacting with the natural environment to fit him properly into society". The essence of education is to aid the person to grow effectively to unlock their potentials. Admittedly, education allows the person to work effectively in the community they are born into or exist in; it instils the community's norms and values in learners.



Dr. Kwame Nkrumah, the first president of Ghana, called for a strict link between education and the sense in which it is supposed to be implemented (Nkrumah 1941). He defined education as exposure meant to prepare a person for participating efficiently in the activities of life and advances the argument that education should, therefore, direct its beneficiaries into the “fullest and most fruitful relationship with the culture and ideals of the society within in which they find themselves” while preparing them for life’s challenges (Nkrumah 1941, p.87).

In Nkrumah’s book, *Conscience: Philosophy and Ideology for Decolonization and Development*, he takes up a central position on the spectrum of ideas that expound on the role of culture in deciding, sustaining, and advancing strategies for education and growth in Africa (Nkrumah, 1970). He highlighted the critical value of traditional African societies’ intellectual production and its importance in shaping a self-conscious and confident African individual and community. Du Bois (1973) held similar views. According to Du Bois, African education “should be founded on a knowledge of the history of their people in Africa and the United States and other parts of the African diaspora, and their present condition(s)” (Du Bois, 1973, p. 93). Du Bois (1973) indicated that an individual of African descent needs to know “the history of their people in Africa,” “the slave trade and slavery,” “abolition,” and “the struggle for emancipation” (Du Bois, p. 150). After a thorough and analytical examination of classical, current continental and diasporan African history, Du Bois found an instructor slightly willing to continue with the educational phase centred on African people.

Nyerere’s Education policy for Self-reliance emphasised the argument that education at all levels should be important to the society in which a learner lives. A student should live in a community and contribute, through practice, to the growth of that specific area. The international definition of education that the educated must serve the state, which is generally segregated for society, should be rejected and replaced by value-oriented and holistic Education (Nyerere, 1967). According to Nyerere (1967), education must promote the social goals of working together for the shared vision. It must prepare young people to play diverse and positive roles in creating a society where all people participate equitably for the group’s good. Its success is quantified to human wellbeing, not automobiles, prestigious houses, or other issues, whether secretly or openly held. Hence, education ought to teach a sense of responsibility to society and assist society in embracing the expectations suitable to a better outlook, not those acceptable to the past (Nyerere, 1967).

A Pan-African educational philosophy is a step towards developing the continent at human, social, economic, and political levels. However, Africans cannot attain any significant growth if they do not resolve some of the recurrent legacy of history: the mental repercussions and interiorised biases inherited from colonial masters, which continue to keep us from redefining oppression narratives and occupying the position we deserve in the world (Austin, 2010).

DECOLONISING PEDAGOGY

Pedagogy is the art and science of teaching and learning, how they are carried out or transpire, and how students comprehend what they are taught (Cogill, 2008). He explained that teaching and learning are what an educator or lecturer should know and the instructor's skills to command to clarify the numerous different teaching and learning choices. Therefore, pedagogical activities include teaching and learning, the instructional process, the various methods by which material is taught, and learners' take-aways from the lesson. Additionally, pedagogy extends beyond classroom instruction to more in-depth work on teaching and decision-making. Without a firm grasp of pedagogy, no practical learning happens, as it is concerned with how learners learn and how education should be carried out.

Heleta (2016) argues that decolonisation integrates African viewpoints, experiences, and epistemologies as the curriculum's core tenets: teaching, studying, and research in the education systems. Returning to African epistemology traditions to improve the pedagogical methods used to communicate knowledge is one way to ensure that African perspectives and experiences become more prominent in general education. Before the advent of colonisation, the pedagogical methods need to be revisited and improved to provide teaching and learning decolonisation (Fomunyan, 2017). Decolonising pedagogy is about creating and using approaches to help students realise that colonisation mechanisms still exist and manage or abolish those structures.

It is also about designing and deploying strategies and techniques which challenge those structures at an individual and group level, resulting in the re-entering of indigenous or African ways of thinking or teaching and learning, being and doing, and encourage engagement with opportunities for making change using the knowledge experienced (Fomunyan, 2017).

In Paulo Freire's book, *The Pedagogy of the Oppressed* (1969), Typically, he contended, education has been organised as a form of wisdom banking – selection and reiteration – thus dehumanising the student (as cited in Holst, 2006). In post-apartheid South Africa, the research found that memorisation trumps inquiry (Adebisi, 2016). According to Freire (1968), information is created and transformed through continuous human investigations into the environment. The author asserts that education should go beyond simply comprehending the world and include efforts to improve it; knowledge should change and inspire participants, not merely adapt to the idealised picture. He was a strong advocate of the importance of education reflecting participants' lived experiences – their situation. Freire (1968) asserted that the 'oppressed' must themselves 'uncover the world of oppression' to accomplish these goals (as cited in Holst, 2006). This can be achieved by an equal connection of discussion so that education 'expresses the teachers' and students' consciousness. He acknowledged that postcolonial leaders could put themselves in the shoes of colonisers and use education to silence, just like the colonisers.

He emphasised the paradoxical relationship between solitude and independence. Freire (1968) recognised that education had transformative capacities and could be used to alter history; in doing so, he echoes postcolonial deconstruction's thesis of educational possibility.

Kanu (2011) noted that classrooms with rigorous integration of indigenous pedagogy surpassed their counterparts on tests and exams, displayed higher-level thought and trust, and among indigenous students, there had been better attendance. Similarly, Hamilton-Ekeke and Dorgu (2015)

indicate that incorporating indigenous approaches into schools improves educational outcomes for both students and teachers by offering an education that is consistent with an indigenous person's different insights, perspectives, dialect, and traditions, thereby easing kid's switchover into the domain of adulthood. Pedagogical methods are crucial in the decolonisation of education. Until this is achieved, decolonisation will still be a foreign concept in education—decolonisation of the current pedagogy is one way of guaranteeing that Africa's education system is decolonised.

DECOLONISING CURRICULUM

Grumet (1981) describes the curriculum as what and how instructors wish for their students to acquire knowledge of the organised subject matter taught in a school. A curriculum is structured to ensure that information is delivered systematically and planned to transmit a combination of knowledge and skills that are defined to be relevant and essential to the community and the time. Aoki (1991) proposed that, in addition to being designed and taught, the curriculum should be taught as lived (curriculum-as-lived) to enable students to criticise and decolonise it as necessary. It's worth noting that a curriculum might take on various forms, including explicit, hidden, or null (Le Grange, 2014). The explicit curriculum is a structured collection of carefully selected and organised explicit learning materials. It promotes critical thinking by providing learners with the tools necessary to critique learning materials and, if necessary, decolonise the curriculum. Several explicit curriculum references entail assessment guidelines, expert demonstrations, and reader-recommended textbooks. A hidden curriculum is where students learn while also being imbued with the coloniser's existing culture and values. The term "null curriculum" pertains to any subject material omitted from a curriculum. These prompt schools to consider what, where, who, how, and why of curriculum decolonisation. Van Wyk and Higgs (2011) asserted that the curriculum assumes a critical element in reconstructing educational discourse, including implementing a curriculum in an African context. Education concepts are placed into motion; even the ideals, convictions,

and principles concerning learning, comprehension, knowledge, disciplines, individuality, and community are realised.

Garuba (2015) suggested that a 'fundamental question of location, perspective, and orientation needed to be answered in any nuanced understanding of the curriculum' and that Africa needed to be put at the centre of teaching and learning. He pointed out two approaches that one needs to consider when discussing the decolonisation of Africa's curriculum. The first strategy is to supplement an existing curriculum with new items. The second strategy is to reconsider how well the product of the study is composed and then reconstruct it and effect fundamental change (Garuba 2015). The first approach is primarily practised in our education system today. This approach seeks to maintain the status quo, as it still hinges on Eurocentric worldviews in the curriculum and only adds bits and pieces of Africa's worldview. This approach is just an attempt to show that they are busily decolonising the curriculum. The decolonisation of the curriculum should enable Africans to decide their purpose through liberating from the subordination and animosity presented within different forms, such as being socially, hereditarily, and naturally unequal to Eurocentric narratives of themselves. Lebelloane (2017) asserts that one of the main risks of not decolonising the curriculum is assimilation and the destruction of the students' life. Students may lose their being or essence, including their communities, identities, native dialects, norms, and values.

Decolonising the curricula must be geared towards adopting Pan-African education curricula that embrace indigenous knowledge systems. It must recognise indigenous thought systems as equally legitimate in the arena of knowledge systems worldwide. Additionally, Okolie (2003) asserts that colonial education did contribute to the alienation of traditional knowledge and ways of thinking in African development debates; a Pan-African education, he claims, can revert this trend toward genuine change in Africa's rural communities. Matos (2000) argued that a significant 'disease' in Africa's education and science is an institutionalised effort to marginalise the inherent value of Indigenous people, dialect, traditions, and practices. Therefore, Africa's educational curricula should be deeply rooted in the cultural and intellectual environment of the society in which it is situated. There is a need to ask important questions about the kind of information embedded in the curricula and the medium of instruction.

Pan-African educational philosophy pays close attention to our Indigenous African knowledge systems; hence, it needs to be familiarised and institutionalised in the academic contexts and curricula. The focus on an African background needs special consideration in our educational systems. Henceforth, underpinning the justification of the curriculum, Pan-African, is to communicate the authenticity of their voices to a diverse learner community. Learners should be inspired to make meaningful connections between the curriculum's content and their social links. Additionally, the references above should be regarded as critical sources of information for making rational choices and leading productive lives..

WHY THE NEED FOR A PAN-AFRICAN EDUCATION?

A vital feature of Pan-African education is that it emphasises our indigenous information structures. Our indigenous experience is embedded within the African metaphysical thinking and social practices developed over thousands of years. Colonial education has erased our indigenous knowledge on agriculture methods, traditional healing, medicinal practices, societal beliefs, and artisan communities. Presently, our local dialect is prohibited in most African schools; almost all the textbooks we use are written in a European language. Those who can read and write in their local dialect are seen as having low proficiency in a language they are entirely unfamiliar with. In many parts of Africa, the medium of communication at home is poorly understood by the teacher. Pan-African education is strongly focused on the essential human experience of the culture in which it emerges and represents the African philosophy, thinking or ideology (Adebisi, 2016).

Adodo (2018) argued that most African countries are not developing because they lack specific current growth information and are swamped with irrelevant knowledge that prevents them from growing. Pan-African education will provide learners with a perspective on how our ancestors tackled life problems down the generations. Additionally, their approaches can help us comprehend the various ways in which reality and fact are perceived. Finally, nation-building will enable the government to address the country's prevailing tribal, cultural, and religious tensions, which present formidable barriers to national development.

Pan-African education is grounded in the philosophy that serves the interest of Africans first and foremost. Azenabor asserts that "Africa's educational system naturally leads to unemployment because the students are not trained to generate jobs independently" (Azenabor, 1999, p.70). He indicated that we incorporate international courses that are unnecessary and unproductive into our school's curricula only because they are the same as those in Western countries. Pan-African education prepares students for life in their country compared to the present educational system that dissociates the student from the society for which it is supposed to prepare them.

Also, Pan-African education emphasises the appropriate link between education and cultural background and the need for an educated individual to have a fruitful relationship with the values of the community in which they live and have they are with the wellbeing of their co-citizens. There is a great need for the continent to step away from commoditised education, which trains students to suit the capitalist economies' work market. For this purpose, it is fair to return to the ideology of education espoused by our ancestors in shaping the mechanisms of educating Africans. Pan-African education underscores a vision of life in which the present is in a consistent and productive interface with the past to build the future

Pan-African education places vehemence on the use of our indigenous languages as a medium of educating students.

What is interesting is that existing African governments seem to favour European languages in their policies. Shizha (2014) explained that continuing the current language policy is that if it worked well and succeeded in training the workforce needed for Africa under the colonial regime, it could work in postcolonial Africa. However, this colonial tradition can no longer be the vision for contemporary Africa. China uses the Chinese language to train their young ones to move ahead in technology; in the same thing is happening in Europe and America, they use their indigenous language to teach at the various level of education, foreign language is only taught as a subject and not used as the primary mode of communicating in schools. Mandela once said: "If you talk to a man in a language he understands, that goes to his head. If you talk to him in his language, that goes to his heart".

The language used must be one that both the teacher and the student understand; therefore, when students are taught and assessed in the indigenous language, education can become a valuable tool for individual and national development.

The call for a Pan-African education is not an agitation to be anti-west, nor is it intended to discourage learning from their worldview. Instead, it is a wake-up call that we need to ensure that our educational system is relevant to our societies' material, historical, and social realities.

HOW DECOLONISING EDUCATION CAN DEVELOP AFRICA

A decolonised education system can contribute immensely to the development of Africa, can be viewed as a medium for communicating values and attitudes that support growth or as one of the social frameworks that a country can deploy as a foundation for development (Morris, 1996). Pan-African education cultivates people's qualities that make for good citizenship, such as fairness, selflessness, tolerance, commitment, hard work, and moral dignity, all of which provide fertile ground for developing good leadership potential. In addition, it can prepare a child to be a responsible member of society and create an identity. For instance, In Korea and Taiwan, the promotion of patriotism and respect for national goals were emphasised as the key goals of education (Tilak, 2001).

Thus, education was critical in these economies' emergence from tumultuous and ruined periods in their histories and in each one's ability to thrive as a stable society and a steadfast national society in a world economy that is rapidly globalised. Also, Pan-African education encourages a competitive culture by allowing people to discover their innovative potential and apply it to improve their current skills and techniques for performing specific tasks, thus increasing their particular target actions (Maekae, 2013). People are trained to be beneficial to themselves and the community they live in through education. This requires them to be active and explore their artistic talents, which they can then apply to specific tasks to achieve self-actualisation and, in the long run, contribute to national development and the development of Africa as a whole.

CONCLUSIONS & RECOMMENDATION

According to Nyerere, people must be set free through education, depending on their growth and realise their full potential. For this purpose, the paper calls for the decolonisation of our educational system by implementing curricula and pedagogy, which aligns with the Pan-African epistemology. The idea is to help resolve the problem of reproducing colonial knowledge unsuitable for Africa and avoid creating an African “elite” separate from African realities. We must shift our students’ roles from passive receivers of information to reflective thinkers and problem solvers and place a greater focus on practical learning rather than theoretical learning (Murungi et al., 2019). We must adopt a Pan-African education that pays close attention to the essential human condition of the culture. It emerges and represents the African world-view, thinking or ideology (Adebisi, 2016).

In light of the effects of colonialism and globalisation on Africans, we must understand and accept African cultures’ importance in decolonising educational systems to improve students’ academic outcomes.

African states, policymakers, and curriculum designers should take the lead in promoting a Pan-African educational paradigm as a means of redefining school knowledge for African students. States must reconsider pedagogical methods to accommodate community experts as potential teachers, especially for the community-centred skills and capability. Also, curriculum designers should integrate self-reliance skills modelled after African indigenous knowledge traditions into our current educational framework. Finally, the African practice of wholesome moulding of each child into a functioning and self-reliant member of the family and society, all community members share in children’s education, must be adopted.

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